

Interaction with Sponsor (Planning a Site Visit)

DAEN 459 Fall 2025
Alexander Abuabara



Advisors: identifying and approaching

- **Review potential matches**
 - Check ISEN faculty research areas
 - Reflect on your project's needs and interests
- **Reach out professionally**
 - Draft a concise introductory email (project topic, goals, timeline)
 - Request a brief meeting to discuss mutual fit
- **Prepare for meetings**
 - Be ready to explain your project vision
 - Bring initial notes from your first meeting
- **Confirm commitment**
 - Secure agreement and establish possible meeting cadence
 - Inform me and Nathan once advisor is confirmed

Project charter: capture clear, actionable project needs

After the 1st meeting with sponsor ...

- Draft project plan → initial charter outline
- Identify gaps in requirements, assumptions, and constraints
- Re-assign roles?
(notetaker, lead, etc.)
- Estimate resources, best/educated guess
(Brainstorm, plan scenarios for time, skills, any type of cost)
- Draft a sequence of activities and a project schedule framework
(set of tools, processes, and methods for developing and controlling a project's timeline)
- Get started identifying risks and planning mitigations
- Finalize first project charter draft (next week)
(in parallel to the project management plan if possible)

Drafting questions & follow-up messages

- Be specific and concise
(“What format should the dataset use?”)
- Prioritize by urgency and impact (critical path first)
- Avoid assumptions; confirm facts (“Can we assume ...?”)

Message template

- Greeting – Address sponsor respectfully
- Thank You – Acknowledge time and input
- Summary – Recap key points from last meeting
- Action Items – List clarifications or next steps
- Next Meeting Proposal – Offer times/dates or request confirmation

Best practices

- Use a single team email thread or project board
- Confirm receipt and agreements in writing
- Update faculty advisor on major changes or risks

Contacts

- **Baker Hughes:**
Elizabeth Lafferty elizabeth.lafferty@bakerhughes.com
Mauricio Valadares Mauricio.Valadares@bakerhughes.com
- **College of Engineering:**
Farzan Sasangohar sasangohar@tamu.edu
- **MerLion Advisory:**
Arnie Tyler atyler@MerLionAdvisory.com

Always cc-me abuabara@tamu.edu and Nathan nmarassa@tamu.edu

“Least but not last”

To keep meetings on track:

- Starting with the next meeting, group leaders will also be hosts on Zoom, and they must **remove** anyone who does not **behave appropriately**.
- Discuss within your group what the minimum expectations should be, as this will affect everyone in the group.